# Instagram & your child:
## a parent's plain-english safety guide

CYBER SAFETY GUY

## Introduction

> I spent 8 years inside the evidence.
> Now I spend my time making sure children never become part of it.

Dala McGleenon's background in digital forensics provides the authority for this guide, but his goal is to provide warm, direct support for worried parents.

### WHAT IS INSTAGRAM AND WHY CHILDREN LOVE IT

**Share and express**
Share photos, videos, Stories and Reels to express themselves.

**Likes and validation**
Likes, comments and follows provide instant feedback.

**Explore and discover**
Explore new content, trends and creators through the Explore page.

**Connect and belong**
Stay in touch with friends and feel part of a community.

## The risks parents need to understand

**Inappropriate content**
Mature themes, violence and harmful content can appear in feeds, Reels and Explore.

**Stranger contact**
Public accounts and DMs can lead to unwanted contact or grooming.

**Privacy and data**
Personal information can be exposed and used by scammers or malicious actors.

**Too much screen time**
Endless scrolling can impact sleep, focus, self-esteem and mental wellbeing.

**Comparison and self-image**
Curated content can cause comparison and lower self-confidence.

**Scams and spending**
Influencer promotions, scams and in-app purchases can be misleading and costly.

## Step-by-step security guide

**1. Enable Family Centre**
Settings > Supervision > Set up supervision. Add your teen and agree on boundaries together.

**2. Make your account private**
Settings > Privacy > Account privacy > Private account. Only approved followers can see their content.

**3. Limit interactions**
Settings > Privacy > Messages. Limit who can message you to 'People you follow'.

**4. Control comments**
Settings > Privacy > Comments. Choose 'Your followers and people you follow' or 'No one'.

**5. Hide your Story**
Settings > Privacy > Hide story and live. Hide from specific people.

**6. Manage your time**
Settings > Your activity > Time management. Set daily time limits and take breaks.

**7. Turn off personalised ads**
Settings > Account Centre > Ad preferences > Ad settings. Limit data used for ads you see.

## The 10-minute conversation

- Ask open questions: "What do you enjoy most on Instagram?"
- Talk about what they see on Explore, Reels and Stories.
- Explain why not everything online is real or safe.
- Agree on rules for time, followers and what to share.
- Remind them they can always come to you.

### The "10-minute chat"

Sit down with your child and ask them to show you how they use the app, focusing on understanding their world rather than judging it.

## If things go wrong

**Stay calm and take screenshots**
Save evidence of the content, messages or profile.

**Report on Instagram**
Use the three dots on the post, profile or message to report.

**Report and seek help**
Report serious issues to CEOP (ceop.police.uk) or Childline.

For urgent concerns, contact your local police.

## Closing

**Onwards & Upwards**

Staying on top of digital safety is hard work, but you are not alone in this fight.

**Childline support:** If you or a child you know needs support, Childline is available 24/7 at **0800 1111** or **childline.org.uk**.